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Formatting of `std::error_code`

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§ 1. Introduction

This paper proposes making `std::error_code` formattable using the formatting facility introduced in C++20 (`std::format`).

§ 2. Motivation

`error_code` has a rudimentary `ostream` inserter. For example:

```
std::error_code ec;  
auto size = std::filesystem::file_size("nonexistent", ec);  
std::cout << ec;
```

This works and prints `generic:2`.

However, the following code doesn't compile:

```
std::print("{}\n", ec);
```

Unfortunately, the existing inserter has several issues, such as I/O manipulators applying only to the category name rather than the entire error code, resulting in confusing output:

```
std::cout << std::left << std::setw(12) << ec;
```

This prints:

```
generic      :2
```

Additionally, it doesn't allow formatting the error message and introduces potential encoding issues, as the encoding of the category name is unspecified.

§ 3. Proposal

This paper proposes adding a `formatter` specialization for `std::error_code` to address the problems discussed in the previous section.

The default format will produce the same output as the `ostream` inserter:

```
std::print("{}\n", ec);
```

Output:

```
generic:2
```

It will correctly handle width and alignment:

```
std::print("{:>12}\n", ec);
```

Output:

```
[  generic:2]
```

Additionally, it will allow formatting the error message:

```
std::print("{:s}\n", ec);
```

Output:

```
No such file or directory
```

(The actual message depends on the platform.)

The main challenge lies in the standard's lack of specification for the encodings of strings returned by `error_category::name` and `error_code::message` / `error_category::message` ([syserr.errcat.virtuals](https://ericniebler.com/2017/02/19/sysexception-usage/)):

```
virtual const char* name() const noexcept = 0;
```

Returns: A string naming the error category.

```
virtual string message(int ev) const = 0;
```

Returns: A string that describes the error condition denoted by `ev`.

In practice, implementations typically define category names as string literals, meaning they are in the ordinary literal encoding.

However, there is significant divergence in message encodings. `libc++` and `libstdc++` use `strerror[_r]` for the generic category which is in the C (not "C") locale encoding but disagree on the encoding for the system category: `libstdc++` uses the Active Code Page (ACP) while `libc++` again uses `strerror` / C locale on Windows. Microsoft STL uses a table of string literals in the ordinary literal encoding for the generic category and ACP for the system category.

The following table summarizes the differences:

	libstdc++	libc++	Microsoft STL
POSIX	<code>strerror</code>	<code>strerror</code>	N/A
Windows	<code>strerror</code> / ACP	<code>strerror</code>	ordinary literals / ACP

Obviously none of this is usable in a portable way through the generic `error_category` API because encodings can be and often are different.

To address this, the proposal suggests using the C locale encoding (execution character set), which is already employed in most cases and aligns with underlying system APIs. Microsoft STL's implementation has a number of bugs in `std::system_category::message` ([MSSTL-3254], [MSSTL-4711]) and will likely need to change anyway. This also resolves [LWG4156].

An alternative approach could involve communicating the encoding from `error_category`. However, this introduces ABI challenges and complicates usage compared to adopting a single encoding.

§ 4. Wording

Add to "Header <system_error> synopsis" [[system.error.syn](#)]:

```
// [system.error.fmt], formatter
template<class charT> struct formatter<error_code, charT>;
```

Add a new section "Formatting" [[system.error.fmt](#)] under "Class `error_code`" [[syserr.errcode](#)]:

```
template<class charT> struct formatter<error_code, charT> {
    constexpr typename basic_format_parse_context<charT>::iterator
        parse(basic_format_parse_context<charT>& ctx);

    template<class FormatContext>
```

```

    typename FormatContext::iterator
        format(const error_code& ec, FormatContext& ctx) const;
};

```

```

constexpr typename basic_format_parse_context<charT>::iterator
    parse(basic_format_parse_context<charT>& ctx);

```

Effects: Parses the format specifier as a *error-code-format-spec* and stores the parsed specifiers in **this*.

error-code-format-spec:

*fill-and-align*_{opt} *width*_{opt} *s*_{opt}

where the productions *fill-and-align* and *width* are described in [\[format.string\]](#).

Returns: An iterator past the end of the *error-code-format-spec*.

```

template<class FormatContext>
    typename FormatContext::iterator
        format(const error_code& ec, FormatContext& ctx) const;

```

Effects: Let *s* be *ec.message()* transcoded into the ordinary literal encoding, with maximal subparts of ill-formed subsequences substituted with U+FFFD REPLACEMENT CHARACTER per the Unicode Standard, Chapter 3.9 U+FFFD Substitution in Conversion, if the *s* option is used, otherwise *format("{}:{}", ec.category().name(), ec.value())*. Writes *s* into *ctx.out()*, adjusted according to the *error-code-format-spec*.

Returns: An iterator past the end of the output range.

Modify [\[syserr.errcat.virtuals\]](#):

...

```

virtual string message(int ev) const = 0;

```

Returns: A string of multibyte characters in the execution character set that describes the error condition denoted by *ev*.

§ 5. Implementation

The proposed `formatter` for `std::error_code` has been implemented in the open-source `{fmt}` library ([FMT]).

§ References

§ Informative References

[FMT]

Victor Zverovich; et al. *The {fmt} library*. URL: <https://github.com/fmtlib/fmt>

[LWG4156]

Victor Zverovich. *`error\_category` messages have unspecified encoding*. URL: <https://cplusplus.github.io/LWG/issue4156>

[MSSTL-3254]

Visual Studio 2022 std::system_category returns "unknown error" if system locale is not en-US. URL: <https://github.com/microsoft/STL/issues/3254>

[MSSTL-4711]

Sung Po-Han. *Should `std::error\_code::message` respect the locale set by the user?*. URL: <https://github.com/microsoft/STL/issues/4711>